



1 **Octola** is an Arctic retreat hidden deep in Finnish Lapland

2 The place also offers snowmobiling experiences

vineyard, with a chef for food and wine pairings.

Data from a white paper by Visa Consulting & Analytics (VCA) shows that emerging affluent consumers spend about 28% on travel. It rises to nearly 58% among the ultra-elite. In contrast, retail's share declines from 49% to 28% across these segments.

Demand is also emerging from smaller towns. UnWild Planet has organised expeditions to Antarctica for families from Ahmedabad, Jaipur, and Guwahati. In December 2025, an Ahmedabad family of 12 undertook a seven-day Antarctica expedition before taking a private jet over Patagonia, Atacama Desert, Easter Island, Iguazú Falls and Bogotá.

These experiences come at a cost. A two-week Antarctica expedition involving a flight across the Drake Passage begins typically at ₹40-45 lakh per person, and ₹50-55 lakh for business-class travel.

At Octola Private Wilderness in Finnish Lapland, founder Janne Honkanen is seeing a similar preference for privacy, flexibility and immersion.

"Our guests are typically very experienced travellers, so for them the luxury experience they are looking for with us is often less about material things and more about access to things that are simple, yet increasingly rare: complete privacy, space, untouched nature, clean air," says Honkanen, adding that some very prominent and affluent families from India have stayed at Octola.

Prices for a two-bedroom villa start at €18,000 a night, including meals prepared by chefs, butler service, private wilderness guide, private spa, etc.

Indian families are opting for private husky and snowmobile adventures, reindeer encounters, Sámi cultural experiences, wilderness dining and Northern Lights excursions. Average stays are five nights, and some guests extend their visits to seven nights.

At Octola, demand around Christmas is so strong that waiting lists can stretch to one or two years, with bookings already being accepted for Christmas and New Year 2027-28.

THE TASTE OF LUXURY

Dining is another major beneficiary. The attraction is not simply an expensive meal at a celebrated restaurant, but the experience surrounding it: exclusive chef interactions, private dining, and culinary encounters that cannot easily be replicated.

According to Bain, the global gourmet food and fine dining market reached about €72 billion in 2024, growing at 7-9%. By 2025, it had expanded to €74 billion, growing another 5% at current ex-